from which China emerged as a more powerful actor on the geopolitical landscape, reducing the asymmetry of power vis-à-vis the US. What Xi has done is reinforce these shifts and unveil plans and programmes which follow from them. The BRI, the AIIB, the occupation and militarization of several disputed islands in the South China Sea and the more frequent use of punitive commercial measures in pursuit of its geopolitical objectives evolved out of an altered strategic view, deemed more favourable to China.

It is in domestic politics and ideology that Xi has made more significant departures from the past, reversing or reorienting some of the landmark political and economic reforms associated with Deng Xiaoping and his successors, Jiang Zemin and Hu Jintao. Soon after taking office as Party and state leader, Xi launched a major anti-corruption campaign, which resulted in the purge of several senior Party cadres, bureaucrats and military officers. Some of the targets conveniently happened to be either political rivals of Xi's or those belonging to a hostile faction within the Party. However, there is no doubt that the anti-corruption campaign has reduced corruption in the system and is certainly very popular among the people. Xi has been constant in his warnings that corruption has corroded the Party's ideals and its political legitimacy and is a threat to the survival of the country's one-party Leninist state. The collapse of the CPSU and the disintegration of the Soviet Union, Xi has said, is because the Party lost its ideological moorings, allowed the Party spirit to become weak, and also because the Soviet military did not act, first and foremost, as defender of the Party. These lessons, Xi said, had to be inculcated afresh among Party cadres (in China), and the leadership of the Party in every sphere of the nation's life had to be entrenched without exception.

This has led Xi to bring about some major departures from Deng's policy prescriptions. Deng brought about a relative separation of the state from the Party, allowing the organs of the state to be managed by professionally qualified persons and experts in their respective fields. Ideological rectitude was no longer the overriding factor in selection. The Party was expected to play a supervisory role.

Drawing lessons from the disaster of the Cultural Revolution, traced